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South Asia's Most Popular Electronics Magazine

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stage and should also be supported by a good number of developers, as well as some key organisations,” explains Mahajan.

He adds, “Then comes restrictions of licensing. If the solutions you are deploying are largely restricted by licensing, you might find yourself hanging by a thread. Licensing assessment should be checked in all the cases as organisations will depend a lot on the solution, and this dependency might increase as the time passes. The licensing should not be too restrictive.”

Availability of commercial third party support options is something that organisations looking to deploy open source solutions should always assess. There should be more than a handful of vendors who can support the solution that an organisation is deploying. This will not only help in cost negotiations but also in choosing the best support possible.

“Open source also has dual licensing models available where there is vendor lock-in. Organisations must look at what are the things where vendor lock-in is applicable. For example, if an organisation does not take subscription from the vendor, can it still use the solution?” explains Mahajan.

The open source solution that an organisation adopts should have transparency. There have been instances where vendors have used open source just as a base combined with their own codes. Such vendors do not generally allow the organisations to use these codes. The ability to integrate such solutions with other solutions also matters a lot as desired results usually warrant the use of multiple solutions at the same time. It is critical for these solutions to work in harmony with each other.

“If you are deploying ERP, you will have to integrate with CRM, with web, with social media and more. We live in a world of integration, and if the solution you are

deploying does not have the capability of getting integrated with other solutions, do not choose it,” says Mahajan.

More on the menu

Apart from the check points mentioned above, there is still more that organisations can do to assess risks attached with adopting the open source solution they are interested in. For instance, while a check on the quality of services provided with the solutions is something no organisation will miss, there is a possibility of missing out checking the governance model of the provider creating and enabling that solution. What if there are only three to five people managing the entire governance model, and one fine day they decide to change the model?

“Though the features of such solutions might be good, but lack of a governance model will mean that there is a lack of support. It also means that the solution might not be sustainable in the long term,” explains Mahajan.

The attributes of a sustainable open source solution include availability of community support, good documentation around the project, a thriving ecosystem of developers and contributors, transparent licensing model, and an up-to-date security reporting model. What kind of organisations are supporting the solution matters a lot. For instance, solutions being supported by the likes of Facebook will always have high credibility over others.

“Based on the above, open source policy documents should always be made for the organisations. These documents should clearly mention the advantages, the risks, licensing policies, and the total cost of ownership involved. The policy document should also explain the alignment of the solution with business and IT. If it is not aligned with businesspeople, organisations will not adopt it,” says Mahajan. **EFY**